



The
Research
Society

AI Guidelines

The Research Society

AI Guidelines

Contents

Introduction to the Guidelines:

Setting out the background to the guidelines, their purpose and goals including advice on how to read and interpret them.

Section 1:**AI in Sampling, Data Collection and Research Design**

(Includes risks, use of Generative AI in questionnaire design, discussion guide development, sampling and predictive sampling, collecting data using AI)

Section 2:**Ethical Considerations and Participant well-being**

(Includes risks of harm or misrepresentation, emotional safety, AI-human interaction governance, escalation protocols)

Section 3:

AI in Analysis and reporting (Includes summarisation and hallucination, sentiment and emotion analysis, AI-generated visuals, synthetic data)

Section 4:

Bias and Fairness in AI models (Includes bias, model training and dataset diversity, human oversight, cultural and regional sensitivity)

Section 5:

Data Privacy & Security (Includes respondent rights, informed consent, data governance, secure handling, and third-party tools)

Section 6:

Transparency and Disclosure in AI use (Includes disclosures during design, data collection, participant and client communication)

Section 7:

Intellectual Property and ownership (Includes IP risks, authorship, attribution, client data rights, third-party tool ownership and licensing)

Appendices

Appendix A

Glossary of Definitions

Appendix B

Ethical References and Related Frameworks

Appendix C

The Research Society Contact points

Appendix D

List of Contributing Authors

Appendix E

Version Control

Introduction to the Guidelines

The purpose of these AI Guidelines is to support members of The Research Society navigate opportunities and challenges presented by application of artificial intelligence (AI) in market and social research. AI is an evolving technology that is increasingly embedded in many aspects of research work, from data collection and analysis to reporting and communication.

Our aim with the AI Guidelines is to help members understand how to apply the principles of The Research Society's [Code of Professional Behaviour](#) when using AI. Rather than imposing additional rules or restrictions, this document is intended as a practical and flexible resource. It offers clarity on how existing ethical and professional standards relate to AI use, helping researchers make confident, informed decisions across the many. It also identifies applicable laws and regulations which require legal compliance, particularly in relation to data privacy and security.

We also highlight that AI is rapidly evolving and that providing specific advice on how to use it would mean the Guidelines quickly become dated. We have therefore not sought to educate members about how to use AI, nor the complex mathematics, technologies and systems that enable it. There are many applications for AI in Market and Social Research and educating members about AI is an ongoing goal of the TRS through its program of member education and professional development.

Each section of the AI Guidelines outlines some common use cases, identifies potential risks, and offers practical suggestions to support alignment with the Code. This guidance recognises that there is no one-size-fits-all approach, and different projects may call for different applications of these principles.

In this spirit, when the guidelines use the word “must,” it indicates a requirement based on the Code of Professional Behaviour. The word “should” signals a recommended best practice. This approach allows members to apply the guidance in ways that make sense for their specific context, supporting professional judgment and thoughtful application.

Some of the guidance provided may seem obvious and we know that humans can be even more fallible than AI in various applications. We emphasise, however, that AI is implicitly persuasive in how it presents insights such that even the most seasoned researcher should be reminded about the potential risks and caveats when using it.

Above all, these guidelines are here to help—not to add burden. They are designed to enable the responsible and effective use of AI while safeguarding the quality, ethics, and integrity of our shared profession. They are intended as a reference document when you use AI to help you uphold our collective professional standards whilst supporting our members to adopt and develop new AI methods with confidence.

1. Ethical Considerations and Participant Well-Being

The Code contains guidelines for the ethical conduct of research, including participant safety, respect, and well-being. When AI is integrated into research, there is an increased potential for unintentional harm, misrepresentation, or loss of trust if not managed properly. AI must be used responsibly, with participant rights and wellbeing prioritised at all times. Relevant Rules (7, 8, 21, 27)

What are the risks?

AI systems engaging with respondents can cause harm through generating inappropriate content or causing offense, particularly if used in sensitive or minority audiences. Automated analysis may misinterpret open-ended responses, reinforce stereotypes, or overreach in profiling, leading to unfair representation or distress for participants. Poorly governed AI systems can erode trust by enabling misuse of personal data or generating outputs that contradict the values of respect, accuracy, and transparency required by the Code.

Ensuring Participant Wellbeing

- AI should not be deployed in a manner that may mislead participants about its nature (e.g., simulating human interactions without disclosure). Ensure respondents know when they are interacting with AI and provide mechanisms to opt-out and escalate any concerns or issues to humans. This should include limitations and the potential for error.
- Test AI interfaces prior to launch for potential emotional harm, tone, or cultural misalignment.

Human Oversight and Governance

- For high stakes projects, it may be advisable to implement a governance framework. This may include routinely monitoring AI-participant interactions to detect and address distress or confusion.

- Any AI chatbot interactions (chat logs, decisions made by AI chatbot) should be recorded in a secure, auditable way because this ensures traceability if complaints or data issues arise. As part of this log, it is recommended to establish clear escalation protocols in case of malfunction or participant harm.
- If a complaint or concern is raised about AI harm or ethics, ensure it is assessed meaningfully and respond in line with the requirements of the Code.

Ethics of AI analysis and agency obligations to client

- The Code of practice sets out that research providers should deliver findings that are truthful, clearly presented, and not misleading, ensuring clients can make informed decisions based on the research outcomes. Where AI is used to generate data or summarise findings, researchers should be clear which findings are generated from the project research data as opposed to the model itself.
- Agencies should explain the methods used, including any AI tools, and should disclose relevant limitations, assumptions, or sources of potential bias that could affect interpretation.
- Agencies should not misrepresent data, overstate findings, or withhold information that may materially impact the client's understanding or use of the research. This especially applies to AI and the potential for bias and hallucinations or propensity for a LLM to answer questions generically from its training set rather than the data collected on the project for the client.

2. AI in Sampling, Data Collection and Research Design

Artificial Intelligence (AI) is increasingly being used for:

- Sampling (e.g. predictive sampling and respondent selection)
- Data collection (e.g., chatbots, automated interviewing), and
- Designing questions for both qualitative and quantitative projects (e.g. question generation and adaptive questionnaires, translation)

When employing AI in these areas, its use should align with The Code. Relevant Rules: 8, 17, 18, 20, 21, 25, 35.

What are the risks?

The use of AI in data collection and survey design may amplify existing risks and introduce additional risks, including:

- Unintentional introduction of bias from source models or through model application
- Lack of transparency in how questions or samples are generated
- Potential for AI to create inaccurate or inappropriate survey content
- Privacy and data security risks if sensitive participant or client data is processed by third-party AI platforms
- Ethical concerns if participants are not properly informed about AI involvement (refer Section 3.6)
- AI can be verbose and repetitive which can lead to long surveys with high respondent burden
- AI may not be capable of detecting when a participant is confused, upset, or disengaged and this is a particular risk when interviewing vulnerable respondents

Using Generative AI in Questionnaire and Discussion Guide Design

- AI-generated questions and content should be validated prior to use on projects.
- Where necessary, researchers should validate that questions are sensitive to respondents in their tone, logic and cultural nuances.
- It is good practice to validate model outputs for factual accuracy, relevance to research objectives, appropriate use of any proprietary or sensitive inputs and cultural sensitivity (if any).

Use of AI in Sampling and Predictive/Generative Sampling

{Predictive or Generative sampling refers to selecting data points (or participants), in market research based on predictions made by a model about their likely behaviour, characteristics, or responses}

- Avoid use of PII or sensitive data for AI-driven predictive sampling or use disconnected or locally hosted models. If such use is necessary, informed consent must be obtained in accordance with privacy laws and relevant data protection policies.
- Researchers should satisfy themselves that AI used for sample selection should be free from biases or that identified biases are understood and documented.

Use of AI in Collecting data (interacting with respondents)

- Use clear, plain language to describe AI's role at the beginning of the research interaction. This can include the nature of AI involvement and any additional data processing (see Section 1).
- The use of AI which **directly interacts with respondents** (e.g. chatbots) should be

clearly disclosed to respondents and an AI policy provided separately or as part of the information handling statement. (see also Section 1 for informed consent).

- If chat AI is used in a survey that is client branded, this should be disclosed to the client and appropriate protocols and safeguards to ensure it behaves in line with client expectations.
- Given AI can act unpredictably, pilot testing of AI agents (chatbots, voice assistants) should be conducted to ensure appropriate emotional impact, tone, and clarity. Using diverse testers to identify cultural mismatches or distress triggers can help identify potential issues.
- Embed safeguards in AI conversation flows to ensure polite, neutral language and the ability to detect distress, escalate to a human, or exit appropriately.
- Implement real-time monitoring or scheduled transcript reviews to detect inappropriate or insensitive AI-generated responses. Clear escalation procedures should be in place, with designated responsibility for addressing and resolving issues.
- Closed Loop systems may mean the AI platform can adapt and share feedback across surveys or interviews (from one respondent to another). If this is intended, appropriate consent needs to be obtained from participants. If it is not intended, then the application of AI should be configured to prevent it.
- Extended engagement between AI and respondents over time may risk emotional dependency. Special care and oversight may be needed to safeguard respondent wellbeing for projects where there is extended interactions between AI and humans (oversight, review, checking in etc).

3. AI in Research Analysis and Reporting

Market research has historically relied on people hours to compile, analyse and interpret research data. AI can improve efficiency across these processes, for example:

- Coding topics from open ended responses
- Analysing primary or secondary data and identifying relationships in the data
- Summarising responses (quantitative and qualitative)
- Tagging sentiment from text sources
- Creating visual outputs in reporting.

These capabilities can reduce manual work and increase insights. The Code (Rule 35) requires that data analysis and reporting should be **objective, transparent, and accurate**, ensuring the integrity of research findings and our industry as a whole. To meet these requirements, it is critical to understand how AI is used, what system controls are in place and what is produced. Relevant Rules: 32, 33, 34, 35, 36.

What are the risks?

While AI tools operate on algorithmic processes, they are not immune to producing flawed or misleading outputs, and do not guarantee that the outcomes are unbiased, accurate, or contextually appropriate. Most LLMs include disclaimers that results may not be accurate. These risks, if unmanaged, may undermine both the credibility of the research and the well-being of participants. Hallucination is a particular risk because AI may produce outputs that are disconnected from the input data. This can manifest in fabrication of verbatims or quotes, invented summaries or patterns or inferred content or meaning that does not exist in the data, especially when applying text analytics.

Special care is also needed to avoid creating or magnifying bias when using AI. AI can project trends or impute missing data inappropriately. Using generative summaries from quantitative data into natural language can be inaccurate or applications of statistics can be missed or misunderstood. Using AI to create images from data or qualitative feedback may cause misrepresentation or inappropriate

impressions based on inapt use or lack of explanation.

Using AI for summarisation

{Summarisation with AI involves condensing information from a larger text into a shorter form, using either extractive summaries, which select and compile key sentences from the original text, or abstractive summaries, which generate new sentences that capture the main ideas in the AI's own words}

- Accountability for summaries must be retained by those responsible for delivering insights. Do not rely exclusively on AI for synthesis or summarisation without validation. Always ensure processes are in place to identify hallucination, bias and factual disconnects (i.e. you should ensure you understand the source of the insight within or outside of the data set).
- It is good practice to ask AI to explain its reasoning when generating answers to questions about the data. This ensures that answers specifically relate to the research data rather than the LLM being applied to the data.
- Retain documentation/audit trails for AI processing so that there is a clear pathway from the source data to the summary - this will help identify any potential for AI hallucination or bias.
- Ask AI vendors if they can provide documentation on underlying models or methods used to generate output free of hallucinations noting these techniques may be proprietary or commercial-in-confidence.

Sentiment and emotional analysis with AI

{Typically, sentiment refers to tagging feedback on a scale from positive to negative whilst emotions are more nuanced psychological mood states e.g. 'joy', 'fear', 'anger' etc.}

- Generated sentiment scores, or tagging or emotional valencies, are estimates and should be treated as such rather than source data in and of themselves. Misattribution can arise due to idioms, use of irony, group dynamics, absence of context, or inexact expression. It is not reasonable to expect AI to be 100% accurate, and it is important when expressing overall metrics to understand the level of accuracy and any reasons for inaccuracy.
- It is good practice to review and validate outputs, especially for sensitive subject matter or where context is important and may not be well handled by generic models. This should be done at the 'case' level through a process of review and correction. Sensitive topics where validation is recommended include health, identity, politics or personal beliefs.
- If using a third-party vendor classification tool, ask for validation benchmarks that show accuracy and precision of outputs

AI-Generated Imagery and Data Visualisation

{Data visualisation with AI uses artificial intelligence to automatically create or enhance visual representations of data, including both generative visuals based on prompts and data-driven visuals shaped directly by underlying datasets}

- AI generated images used in reporting should be labelled to indicate whether they are based on research data or are rather, are illustrative. If visuals are extrapolated, inferred, or not directly supported by data, appropriate disclaimers should be included to avoid interpretation.
- Written consent must be obtained before using client intellectual property in AI tools. Outputs generated from client data or prompts should be treated as proprietary unless otherwise agreed. It is also important to understand and comply with the

intellectual property terms of any third-party AI platforms used. (see Section 7)

- Any AI-generated charts or visualisations should be verified against original datasets to confirm data accuracy, acknowledging that hallucination and bias are risks for image generation, just as they are for text generation and summaries.

Using Synthetic Data in market research

(Synthetic data is artificially generated using algorithms to mimic real data. It may be derived from participant datasets or created entirely from open-source or public data)

- The use of synthetic data should be clearly disclosed in all reports, with stakeholders informed whether it is fully or partially synthetic. Its use must align with participant consent or be limited to non-identifiable modelling tasks.
- It is recommended to seek objective estimates of reliability (e.g. hold-out sampling, external benchmarks or equivalent validation methods) to assess the accuracy and confidence of conclusions drawn from synthetic data. Modelling assumptions and methods and any limitations should be documented and explained clearly in terms that readers can understand.
- For projects with policy implications, sensitive topics, or high public impact ('high stakes' projects), it is advisable to adopt a formal governance framework. This may include independent ethical review, legal consultation, or oversight by a qualified committee to safeguard against misuse or misinterpretation.
- If the goal of synthetic data use is deidentification, then effectiveness should be manually confirmed, and residual risk

assessed, particularly when combining synthetic and real data.

- Synthetic data models should be developed and interpreted by individuals with appropriate expertise, who are responsible for clearly communicating any limitations, uncertainties, and methodological decisions.

4. Bias and Fairness in AI use

The Code provides that Members should carry out research projects in an ethical and professional manner. Ensuring that data accurately reflects the diverse communities, individuals, and customers we represent is a crucial aspect of marketing and social research. This necessitates identifying and mitigating implicit or explicit biases and preconceptions that may influence research outcomes. Relevant Rules: 33, 35.

What are the risks

AI models trained on unrepresentative or biased data can reinforce stereotypes, overlook minority perspectives, and produce misleading or discriminatory outcomes. This can result in inaccurate insights, poor policy or business decisions, and a loss of trust among participants and stakeholders. A lack of transparency in AI model operations and controls further complicates the detection and correction of unfair outputs.

In the Australian context, there is a particular risk that AI-generated outputs may misrepresent or exclude multicultural communities, regional distinctions, or Indigenous perspectives, particularly when training data is not locally sourced. Potential bias arises from use of AI in summarisation, sentiment analysis, text analytics, and image generation without application of system or human controls.

Model Training and Dataset Diversity

- It is important to validate that AI models used are trained on diverse and representative datasets. If there are known biases, they should be identified and the risks they create documented. If possible, strategies should be applied to mitigate known biases. If in doubt, ask providers.

- Where possible, use models which included training sets that reflect Australia's diverse communities, including regional and Indigenous populations. Engage with organisations or representatives to support inclusive data sourcing.
- Where it is reasonable to do so, avoid the risk of bias by using AI tools that have undergone independent bias audits. In practice, application of a model to AI-generated insights against primary datasets (target >85% agreement for validation).
- Review AI tools and outputs for use of relevant cultural norms to the target audience. For example, review application and outputs for culturally sensitive or diverse populations, idioms, tone, and regional content, especially with non-English or minority group engagement. Ensure AI translations reflect localised variations of languages.

Oversight, Monitoring and Contextual Review of AI use and generated content

- Responsibility for biased or discriminatory outcomes rests not only with the platform provider, but also with those who deploy, interpret, or act on AI-generated outputs. It is important to understand the legal and ethical implications of using AI models, especially when they inform decisions related to segmentation, advertising, pricing, or messaging.
- Ensuring fairness and avoiding bias is not just related to data analysis but across the full research lifecycle - from sampling and survey design to interpretation and reporting. Consider how bias in AI models could affect decisions at each stage.
- Use tools with transparent documentation regarding source model training, bias mitigation, and audits. When applying AI

enabled systems, it is important to know what techniques, methods and systems are in place to detect and mitigate bias.

- Establish a documented process for reviewing, correcting, and reporting issues if biased outputs are identified during or after project delivery, and ensure stakeholders are informed of material risks or errors.
- Given the field of AI is constantly evolving, and new bias and fairness issues can emerge as technology advances. It is important to stay informed about the latest developments in AI ethics and bias mitigation. For example, reading academic papers, attending conferences, and participating in professional networking events that are focused on cultural and population biases and fairness in research.

5.Data Privacy and Security

The use of AI in research must align with Australian law, including the Privacy Act 1988 and the Australian Privacy Principles (APPs), as well as The Research Society's Code of Professional Behaviour. The Code requires strict controls over data access, secure storage and processing, and transparent communication regarding the use of personal information. Additionally, client organisations often have their own policies regarding information sharing and data handling. Government agencies typically prohibit offshore data storage, which can be a concern when using AI systems that process data in overseas location. Relevant Rules: 13, 25, 32, 39, 40, 41, 42.

What are the risks?

The use of AI in research creates risks of unauthorised access, accidental disclosure, or misuse of sensitive participant and client data, especially when third-party platforms are involved. Inadequate data security or unclear data handling practices may result in breaches of privacy laws and ethical codes, leading to legal consequences and reputational damage. There is also a risk that AI systems may retain or re-use personal data without

proper consent or enable re-identification of anonymised participants through data aggregation.

Respondent rights – consent, explanation and withdrawal

- When using AI, personally identifiable information (PII) extends beyond names and contact details. It also includes video, audio, and transcripts containing identifiable voices, faces, names, or contextual information that could reasonably reveal an individual's identity. Handling of such data must comply with applicable privacy laws, including the Australian Privacy Principles (APPs), the Privacy Act 1988 (Cth), and, where relevant, the General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) and other regulations applying to countries where data is being collected.
- When identified, participants have the right to understand, access, and control how their data is used, which includes AI systems. The use of AI should therefore be designed and applied in ways that respect and uphold these rights, ensuring transparency, accountability, and informed consent.
- Participants should be informed about how AI will use their identifiable data, with clear, plain-language explanations. They must also be given the opportunity to withdraw consent or request deletion of their data, in line with ethical and legal obligations.
- Participants should be clearly informed when AI is used to process any personally identifiable information (PII), and meaningful, opt-in consent must be obtained. Where applicable, separate consent should also be sought for any secondary use of data in AI development or testing.

Data Governance and Ethical Risk Assessment

- At the planning stage of any AI-related project, members must identify potential privacy and cybersecurity risks, evaluate their impact, and establish documented mitigation strategies. This includes considering legal obligations, ethical implications, and implementing safeguards based on who will access and manage data throughout the research value chain.
- Data collection and processing should be limited to what is necessary to achieve clearly defined research objectives. If personally identifiable information (PII) is involved, any additional use such as model training or secondary analysis beyond the original purpose requires explicit opt-in consent. All data collected must be directly relevant and proportionate to the stated objectives.
- AI-related data handling practices must be clearly disclosed to clients and formalised through written agreement during the project scoping phase. (Rule 15).

Secure Data Handling Practices with AI

To protect participant privacy when using AI, the following measures must be taken:

- Prioritise de-identified or anonymised data for training or testing AI models, and remove or mask personal identifiers before processing data with AI tools
- Limit data collection to only what is needed for clearly defined research objectives, and only collect PII if strictly necessary and with explicit participant consent
- Document and disclose what data is being collected and why, within AI workflows

- Know where your data is processed, including server locations and offshore transfers
- Understand the providers policy for using data for model training and marketing purposes
- Use encryption for data at rest and in transit, and restrict access to unauthorised personnel
- Have breach protocols in place for timely response to data or AI-related incidents

The following measures should be applied where appropriate:

- List the AI tools used (e.g. transcription, analytics, facial recognition) and inform clients of associated risks.
- Conduct due diligence on third-party AI tools for compliance with APPs, the Privacy Act 1988, and standards like ISO 27001 or ISO 20252
- Maintain logs of AI model use (if applicable), including provider details and application purpose

6. Transparency and Disclosure in AI Use

The Code provides that Members carry out research projects in an ethical and professional manner. When a project involves the use of AI, transparency for both the participants and the Client is essential. Relevant Rules: 15, 18, 35).

What are the risks

A lack of transparency in research poses serious risks, including the erosion of participant trust and damage to professional reputation. When clients or participants are not clearly informed about methods, such as the use of AI or automated tools, this can lead to misunderstandings, ethical breaches, and non-compliance with consent requirements. Misleading or incomplete disclosures increase the

likelihood of disputes, legal challenges, and regulatory scrutiny. Ultimately, transparency is essential to maintaining the credibility and integrity of the work.

Transparent use of AI during Research Design and Planning stage

- Section 5 of the Guidelines set out requirements for disclosure of use of AI where participants **interact directly with AI** and **when PII is collected**. There is no requirement to disclose use of AI to respondents in analysis where their PII is not collected.
- It is recommended that suppliers disclose the use of AI to clients on research projects as this will help identify any risks and ensure they are fully informed (Rule 15).
- When a client provides data containing personally identifiable information (PII) for recruitment or analysis, they are subject to the same obligations under privacy law and ethical standards. This includes obtaining informed consent and clearly disclosing the intended purpose of use, to safeguard the individuals whose data is involved.
- Any use of such data, or beyond its original purpose, such as for secondary analysis, AI model training or improvement, or future research, should be clearly communicated and you should proceed with the participant consent when use of PII data is involved.
- Consider the ethical implications of using AI at the outset such as impact of AI on participant experience, privacy, or fairness. Assess whether AI applications align with the intended research goals without introducing unnecessary bias or complexity.

Transparent use of AI during data collection

- Members should clearly disclose any AI tools used during the data collection phase, including how these tools function and the role they play in the research process.
- Both participants and clients should be informed about the use of AI in data collection, and all practices should align with applicable ethical guidelines and privacy regulations.
- When AI is used to interact with participants its use should be clear. This includes the use of tools such as AI-driven chatbots and intelligent survey platforms. Provide simple, accessible explanations of AI's function e.g. "I am a chatbot and my role is to help understand your feedback" or if using third party tools, ensure vendors apply these protocols.
- Consent processes should explicitly inform participants of AI involvement, using plain language that avoids any ambiguity or misunderstanding. Participants should never be misled into believing they are engaging solely with a human if AI technologies are part of the interaction.
- Ensure participants are informed about data protection measures in accordance with Australian privacy regulations.
- Obtain explicit participant consent if AI will process personal or sensitive data.
- If participants withdraw, ensure prompt removal of personally identifiable information from any AI analysis or retraining pools on request, where possible.

7. Intellectual Property and Ownership

The use of AI introduces complex questions of intellectual property (IP), authorship, and data ownership in research. Rule 28 and 35 of The Code emphasise respect for ownership rights and transparency. Copyright protection in Australia generally requires significant human contribution, outputs solely generated by AI may not attract copyright protection. Relevant Rules (16, 28)

What are the risks?

Failure to establish ownership upfront can lead to disputes over client deliverables, unauthorised use of proprietary tools or data, and breaches of confidentiality agreements. These risks are heightened when AI systems contribute to outputs that blend human and machine-derived content, making it essential to clearly document IP arrangements and respect all parties' rights throughout the research lifecycle.

IP Ownership and Contract Clarity

- Define, in contracts or statements of work, who owns the outputs generated by AI, distinguishing between client, agency, and platform/vendor IP.
- Be aware of, and take steps to mitigate, the risk that AI used on projects appropriates client IP through capture, retention OR training of models using client proprietary content.

Copyright and Authorship

- Recognise that copyright applies only to works with sufficient human authorship. When AI is used, document the extent of human creative input.
- For third-party AI tools or LLMs, understand the IP terms and limitations in their licences relating to both input and output.

Attribution and Avoidance of Plagiarism

- Attribute all AI-assisted or AI-generated outputs in accordance with legal and contractual requirements, including third-party content, visuals, or data.
- Review AI outputs to prevent inadvertent use of copyrighted or plagiarised material; edit before dissemination.

Client Data Ownership and Use

- Client-supplied data remains the client's property. Do not use, share, or upload client data to AI tools beyond the agreed project scope and consent.
- Ensure data is securely deleted at project conclusion, in line with contractual obligations.

Separation of Tool and Output IP

- Be clear that the underlying AI tools or models (e.g., SaaS platforms, LLMs) are property of their vendors, unless otherwise agreed.
- Project outputs generated or assisted by those tools typically belong to the client or agency, but this should be stipulated in writing.

APPENDIX A: Glossary of Definitions

- **Artificial Intelligence (AI):** Technologies and systems capable of performing tasks that typically require human intelligence, such as natural language processing, predictive modelling, machine learning, image recognition, and automated decision-making.
- **Accuracy and Precision:** Accuracy refers to how closely AI-generated results or insights reflect the true values or opinions of the target population. Precision describes the consistency and repeatability of the AI's outputs—how reliably it generates the same results under similar conditions.
- **AI Hallucination:** A phenomenon where artificial intelligence, particularly large language models (LLMs) like those used in chatbots, generates false, misleading, or nonsensical information and presents it as fact.
- **Data Privacy:** The ability of individuals to control how their personal information is collected, used, and shared.
- **Data Security:** Measures and protocols that safeguard data from unauthorised access, alteration, disclosure, or destruction.
- **Closed versus Open Loop:** This relates to how AI generates outputs and learning. Open Loop means the model operates without incorporating feedback from its outcomes—once deployed, it runs as-is and is not automatically updated or adjusted based on performance. Closed Loop means the model receives feedback from its outputs or environment and uses that information to continuously improve or adapt over time, often through retraining or real-time adjustment.
- **Emotional Harm:** A negative psychological or emotional response experienced by a participant during or after a research interaction (feeling of distress, anxiety, embarrassment, shame, or discomfort). It can arise from insensitive questioning, AI-generated content that lacks empathy or context, perceived manipulation, or a failure to provide human support when needed.
- **Human Oversight:** Ongoing supervision by qualified personnel to ensure responsible and ethical AI use, including intervention when risks or unexpected outputs are detected.
- **Informed Consent:** Permission given by participants based on clear understanding of the study and its use of AI throughout data collection, analysis, or reporting.
- **Model Training:** LLM training involves processing massive amounts of text data so the model can learn to predict the next word in a sequence. Through this process, it adjusts its internal parameters to capture grammar, context, facts, and patterns in human language.
- **Personal Data:** Any information relating to an identified or identifiable individual, including both direct identifiers and contextual or behavioral data that can reveal identity.
- **Personally Identifiable Information (PII):** Information that can directly or indirectly identify a specific individual, such as a name, address, or identification number.
- **Predictive Sampling:** The use of AI to extrapolate from existing datasets by modelling responses or boosting sample sizes, excluding traditional inferential statistical techniques which do not use machine learning. ADD IN GENERATIVE SAMPLING
- **Sentiment Analysis (AI):** Automated interpretation and labelling of text data on a positive to negative valence. Emotional scoring is more nuanced tagging against psychological feelings such as joy, love, hate etc.
- **Summarisation (AI):** Automated synthesis of qualitative or quantitative data (e.g., open-ends, transcripts).
- **Synthetic Data:** Data that is artificially generated rather than collected from real-world events or participants to mimic statistical properties and patterns of actual data.
- **Transparency:** The obligation to clearly disclose, in plain language, when and how AI is used in any part of the research process, to all relevant stakeholders.
- **Visualisation (AI):** Auto-generated visuals or charts from research data, including generative images from text prompts.

APPENDIX B: Ethical References and Related Frameworks

- The Research Society Code of Professional Behaviour
- NHMRC Standards and Guidelines
- Privacy Act 1988 (Cth)
- Australian Privacy Principles (APPs)
- ISO 20252 (Market, Opinion and Social Research)
- ISO/IEC 27001 (Information Security)
- European GDPR (General Data Protection Regulation)
- OECD AI Principles

- ACM Code of Ethics and Professional Conduct
- UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of Artificial Intelligence

APPENDIX C: Contact points

Reach out to The Research Society for ethics review queries, privacy or data breach notifications, AI tools & vendor guidance requests or Professional conduct support.

APPENDIX D: List of contributing authors, Reviewers

1. Garreth Chandler
2. Chris Sherley
3. Lisa Salas
4. Bianca Le Serra
5. Sonny Sethi

Reviewers

1. Nick Jenkins
2. Michelle Gilmore
3. Rami {Surname needed}
4. Dawn Mischewski

APPENDIX E: Version Control

Version	Date of Change	Change
1.0	26-05-2025	Consolidated copy distributed for joint Review including original content with comments from first reviewers (separate Cover)
2.0	31-05-2025	This document which consolidates, reformats and deduplicates across committee author content
3.0	12.06.2025	Updated version following review by Sonny
4.0	20.06.2025	Version reviewed by Lisa and Bianca to adjust focus on areas that are mandatory (must) versus recommended (should)
5.0	20.06.2025	Final clean draft prepared for reviewers
6.0	05.07.2025	Consolidated reviewer feedback and marked up changes in response
7.0	12.07.2025	Final Draft for board with changes from reviewers made
8.0	28.08.2025	Final Copy incorporating Board Feedback

The Research Society

20-40 Meagher Street,
Chippendale NSW 2008 Australia

Phone: +61 2 9566 3100

Toll Free: 1300 364 832

<https://www.researchsociety.com.au/contact-us>